Chapter 5

Taking Care of Our Environment

Everything around us makes up our environment. Air, water, soil, plants, animals and people are all part of the environment.

Living things need each other

Plants make their own food. Animals cannot make their own food, so they depend on plants or on other animals. A deer eats grass, and a tiger eats the deer. So the tiger also depends on the grass! This chain of who eats whom is called a food chain:

grass - deer - tiger

If all the grass disappeared, the deer would go hungry, and then the tiger would go hungry too.

Garbage

Every day we throw away many things, such as fruit peels, paper, plastic bags and broken toys. All the things we throw away are called garbage or waste. Waste is of two kinds.

- Biodegradable waste breaks down by itself in a short time. Tiny living things in the soil, which are too small to see, help to break it down. Fruit and vegetable peels, dry leaves, paper and leftover food are biodegradable.
- Non-biodegradable waste does not break down for many, many years. Plastic bags, plastic bottles, glass and metal cans are non-biodegradable. They make the soil and water dirty and can harm animals.

Separate your waste

Keep two dustbins at home. Put wet waste, like peels and leftover food, in the green bin. Put dry waste, like plastic, paper and glass, in the blue bin. Separated waste is easier to manage.

Make compost

Dig a small pit in a corner of your garden or keep a pot. Put vegetable peels, fruit peels and dry leaves into it and cover them with a thin layer of soil. After a few weeks, the waste turns into dark, crumbly compost. Compost is a natural manure that helps plants grow.

The three Rs

- Reduce: use fewer things. Carry a cloth bag to the market instead of taking plastic bags.
- Reuse: use things again. Use an old jar as a pencil stand.
- Recycle: send paper, glass and metal to be made into new things.

Let's think

1. What is a food chain? Give one example.
2. What is the difference between biodegradable and non-biodegradable waste?
3. What are the three Rs?

New words

biodegradable - something that breaks down by itself in a short time
compost - manure made from rotting plant waste